

# Search-and-Destroy

**South Vietnam's volatile political situation required a flexible strategy to target enemy combatants, minimize civilian casualties, and keep American troops safe. Search-and-destroy was General Westmoreland's solution.**

## ◀◀ BEFORE

**Search-and-destroy tactics, previously used by the British, were designed for guerrilla warfare.**

### BRITISH PRECEDENT

The British had used search-and-destroy methods against **communist guerrillas in Malaya** in the 1950s, a conflict known as the Malayan Emergency.

### MISSION CHANGE

President Johnson's **escalation of America's role** in Vietnam in 1965 led to a change in mission. In addition to providing security for airbases engaged in **Operation Rolling Thunder**, ground troops assumed an ever-greater share of combat against the Viet Cong in South Vietnam



THE MALAYAN EMERGENCY

**D**espite the complexity of the war's political dimensions, US military authorities settled on a relatively simple strategy to accomplish the US goal of preserving an independent, noncommunist South Vietnam. Ground operations focused on protecting US military installations, destroying the Ho Chi Minh Trail and other supply routes, and wearing down the strength of the enemy through a strategy known as search-and-destroy.

## Key objectives

This strategy of attrition involved locating and killing enemy combatants, discovering and destroying material intended to support the enemy (including food), and identifying and neutralizing people who supported the enemy and their efforts.

The helicopter was essential to such operations. Its unprecedented mobility allowed the delivery of combat troops to remote areas in the jungle and mountains.